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Derek Brown

In a crowded field of jazz saxophonists, Derek Brown has successfully created his own personal sound and performance vibe. In addition to his solo shows, he is a frequent guest artist with academic ensembles both in the U.S. and abroad.

Derek was interviewed via Zoom on March 5, 2021 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very pleased to have, on a Friday afternoon, Derek Brown with me. And we are not together but we're going to be together for about an hour. Thanks for joining me.

DB: Yeah, thanks for having me, Monk. I'm glad to be here.

MR: Congratulations on your, was it last year you did a fifty state tour?

DB: Yeah. Like a year and a half ago. Fifty gigs, fifty states. We made it all. Nine months in an RV.

MR: You couldn't think of anything challenging to do, hey?

DB: No, no. And my wife and I, she got to come with — and we both love to travel. And usually I'm doing gigs by myself like flying here or there. I've been to Europe a lot of times. And a lot of times she doesn't get to come with me. And so we were trying to think of you know what? I should do more stuff in the U.S. and maybe I could string them all together. And when we started putting feelers out for if something could work we were getting a really good response from all over the country. And we were like I wonder if we just go a step further and why don't we just try to get all the states. You know? Why not? Make it a nice theme, like fifty states, fifty gigs.

MR: Well this isn't really a musical question but did you learn anything about America?

DB: Uh let's see, yeah, I'm sure I did. I mean I learned, I mean it's an extremely beautiful country, such a variety of landscapes, even people. But you know we often think of, when you want to go on a vacation, well some people do, like you've got to go to other countries, you've got to go to Europe. But man we have it all here. People often ask me like what my favorite states were and I have to kind of go along with the cliché that yes, Hawaii and Alaska were pretty amazing, because they're both so exotic. But you know there was so much beauty. And we were in the fall in the Northeast, so around like the Finger Lakes and we did the Adirondacks right around, right when it was beautiful colors. And my wife was really good about kind of almost forcing me, I have to say that, forcing me to have — to not schedule a gig every day so that we could have a trip to Acadia National Park or you know, to see the Grand Canyon. So I'm actually quite grateful for that. So instead of my memories of the great United States just being oh yeah

I saw a lot of cool concert halls. It was like no I saw these amazing forests and these valleys and the oceans. You know so it was quite an experience all around.

MR: I want to come back to that later on, about the role music plays in your everyday life, but I'm wondering if you had an incident when you were young, as a kid, that in retrospect seemed to set you on this path that you're on?

DB: And when you said, do you mean like being a professional musician or like the kind of like solo saxophone?

MR: More like okay just being a musician.

DB: Okay.

MR: Was there something that happened to you way back?

DB: Yeah well the ironic thing is when, you know I have fairly musical parents. They've both done choir. My dad was in the University of Michigan Men's Glee Club chorus. My dad's a pastor and so he was always involved with music at the church and things like that. And I remember growing up and doing a little bit of like the hand bell choir and kind of singing. But the ironic thing is when fifth grade came around, which is of course the year most schools around the U.S. offer a band program and it's encouraged to do that, I actually did not want to play an instrument. I just thought I'm happy doing what I'm doing why would I want to learn an instrument. And my parents forced me to pick an instrument. And I remember when I went to this like band introduction day and they had all the instruments on a table, as I was kind of thinking okay what instrument am I going to have to play, which one am I going to pick. And I remember the saxophone was particularly shiny and they let us touch the instruments, all these buttons and valves, you know this machine. But I also remember thinking this looks really expensive. So if my parents are going to make me play they're going to pay for it. I'll play the saxophone, that looks like it's worth the most. You know I could sell it later on when it doesn't work out. So it's funny that that's now my career. And I think a huge thing, because I do master classes all around the country and the world. And I end up saying a lot of the things over and over. And one of the things I really stress with people is that I don't think I have any natural gifts for music. Some people might argue otherwise. But when you hear me doing my solo stuff and I'm doing like four things at once with the stomping and the rings and the jumping back and forth, which we'll probably talk about a little bit. The only reason I can do that stuff is just because I put in the time, you know? And I'm sure a lot of other musicians would say this, if I've any special ability it's the ability to sit in a room by myself for three to five hours every day and just practice my instrument. Just slowly, sometimes painfully slow, practice it. And so when I started playing the saxophone at school I don't think there's anything special it's just the big thing was my

just had a private lesson teacher once a week. And because of that I actually like wanted to be prepared for my lessons. You know it's not a crazy idea. Whereas most of the students, the other kids in my band, they were just doing band and you know didn't have a big reason to be motivated. And I had a teacher that was giving me new stuff. I like to please people. That's another talent or bad —

MR: No it's not bad.

DB: Cool. But I like to please people so much that I like don't want to let them down. And so that naturally just made me want to practice more. And oh wow, they were impressed with my etude last week, I really want to get this one up for next time. You know there's like the two trains of thought. Have you seen the movie "Whiplash"?

MR: Yes.

DB: Okay there's that school of thought where it's like you beat it out of the kid and it's like you stink until you practice and get better. That, oh my gosh, does not work for me. What works for me is the complete opposite — someone saying, "That was really good." And then on my own it's like my gosh, the next time what if they hear me and I'm not as good. They're going to think I'm terrible so I'm going to practice even more, and then just doing that year after year, here I am.

MR: What was the first sort of public performance? Was it in church or in school?

DB: I think it was at school and I remember the first band concert, so it was like at the end of that semester when we started. And I had been doing private lessons. I was probably the only one in my school that had done, in my grade, that had done private lessons. And so my director gave me kind of like a prime solo spot. You know we were playing "Merrily we Roll Along" in unison as a band. But then there was a little mid-break. There might have been a couple of other students that did something special. And I got to do, I played this version of "Amazing Grace" with solo piano. And we still have the video footage of that, you know. It sounded terrible. I remember I was squeaking so much. But I remember like all my bandmates were like so amazed, which is so funny, it's so far ago. And yeah, it's that wanting to please people. And I'll admit at times in my life I have been addicted to the applause and just like wow, hey that felt good. And I hope within that it's not just the applause but maybe I can tweak that and say I love or I'm addicted to seeing the power of music, the effect it has on people, making people happy. That's the less selfish way to phrase that.

MR: Well there's been jazz artists that have not found that motivation. I think that they're playing more for themselves and so that's another way to think about it. You were born in '83? Is that right?

DB: Yeah. Very good. Yeah.

MR: So a couple of things were happening then, one of which, I'm not sure how relevant it is but the change to compact disks from LPs. I wonder if LPs had any role in your life? Because I was one of those guys who used to read the liner notes like to get my jazz history.

DB: Well okay, the bad news is it wasn't LPs but the good news because this is still before Spotify and Napster, the CDs, they were smaller of course but they often still had booklets. And I love that stuff. I was just talking with a friend a little bit ago about how every CD we owned it was that top to bottom, every word you read, I mean one it was just something to do while you're listening to it. Also, you know, being kind of, I was kind of newer to jazz. Like my parents didn't raise me so much on jazz so to speak. I would say they raised me on some good music, some oldies. It wouldn't be strange to hear the occasional classical music. Or like my dad had Brubeck's "Time Out," a couple other things. But when I'm kind of new to that and I'm like what's this instrumental stuff, there's no words. It's like well I might as well kind of read this stuff here and then learning the history makes you appreciate it a little bit more. So I am grateful for those, really, for those liner notes and reading that. Because I think it builds on each other. Listening to good music makes you want to learn about it. Learning about it makes you want to hear it, so I think that was a key thing into my kind of foray into jazz.

MR: Was there a first saxophone player that you heard and you wondered, all right, who is that, and then you started looking for that name?

DB: Yup, all right, so here is where some people are going to judge me, but whatever, I'm going to let it all out.

MR: Now you're going to say Boots Randolph, right?

DB: Nope. I'm going to go even further. Because yeah I actually wasn't introduced to Boots until much later. But I'm actually going to go all the way smooth jazz and I'll say, like I said I was born in '83, I listened to lot of pop music growing up, so the big name if you want to guess. Kenny G.

MR: Kenny G. Yes.

DB: Him and then even more I think my first two saxophone CDs I was given was Kenny G and Dave Koz, so another smooth jazz guy. And I remember, and like I said, I grew up with pop. This was basically pop so this made sense to me, but it was done by a saxophone. It was done by the instrument that I'm playing. And it sounded really good to me. And I'm really grateful for those first two CDs because it was that music that got me to kind of, I think, break outside of the box in the way of like kind of taking it as my own instead of being given music in assignments from my private lesson teacher, which is great, you've got to start somewhere, or my band teacher. I'm just doing what they asked

wanted to like, hey are there transcription books with this? I want to play along with this. And then I remember taking the CD and this little boom box that I had and I would go out to the garage, and this was in Michigan and in the winter it would get really cold in the garage, but it didn't matter, I would go in that garage because it had the best acoustics in the house, you know this nice reverb. And I would put on that Dave Koz and I had my little transcription book and I would just close my eyes and play. And it got me also to kind of play out, like I don't listen so much to smooth jazz these days, but a lot of the tone of these musicians is really nice. And I think a lot of people could learn from the tone of smooth jazz players. Just kind of like really putting air through the horn and making a beautiful sound. And listening to those albums, I would close my eyes and play along and I'd kind of like have the dream of like man I could do this on a stage one day, you know, this is great. And it was, once again, it wasn't an assignment, it was me doing something for the first time on my own with music. It seems small but I think it was a big step.

MR: Very significant. I did the same thing with Cannonball Adderley. Talking about filling the horn.

DB: Yeah.

MR: Like playing it from this end to that end.

DB: What a great sound.

MR: Yeah. And also in the mid 80s the rap music started to become quite popular and I just wondered if that entered your consciousness. Because you're so, you're such a percussive guy.

DB: I am yeah. It's funny, well I didn't always get into rap when I was younger mainly because my parents would not have approved. And I was very much a goody two shoes. You know I talked about wanting to please people, I really wanted to please my parents. It worked for me. I was happy that way, not kind of like stretching the boundaries when I was a kid, though we did listen to — I would often just say, just all the pop music we listened to, the 80s pop, 90s pop, where there's always a backbeat on two and four, just such a universal thing. And you listen to my music nowadays almost always there's a backbeat on two and four. I will never, until I die, I will never get sick of that. I love that. And it's this thing that people say, like they've done studies on this, the music you listen to when you're a teenager, it's going to stay with you your whole life. And so it's like it doesn't matter how cheesy it seems nowadays, it's nostalgic for me. When I hear that, like Bryan Adams, Tears for Fears, whatever that, heavy reverb on two and four, and those synths, it's so nostalgic to me. It just like warms my heart in a way that, and I'll be honest, in a way that a lot of jazz maybe doesn't, just because I didn't grow up with that

dance, experiencing all these things, that's the soundtrack of your growing up. And it's like life is too short to like move beyond that. And I've learned to just embrace it. It's okay. I like the stuff and it's okay if this enters my playing. Yeah.

MR: So have you ever been playing one of your solo numbers and the audience gets into it and they start clapping on one and three?

DB: The worst. No. Yes it definitely has happened. Yeah. And there are some places maybe that do that more than others.

MR: Yes that's very interesting. Someone, it's like you could do a sociological study about where that demarcation is.

DB: Totally. Yeah. And I mean I just love that they're, the fact that an audience is clapping to the music means that it's connecting in some way. And like you were saying, for me, so much of music is connecting with others. It's not just for myself. There is a lot about, for myself, of course. But so much is about sharing this. It's a communication. It's a language. I am thinking about the audience. I want to say something and I want them to be there with me.

MR: I don't know if this is part of your thinking but you have a sound, you have a musical hook, and you even have a descriptive title for what you do. I'm wondering if your career path has been more calculated than some people who just take advantage of serendipitous opportunities, almost like you were going to start a business and you need a business plan.

DB: Yeah, that's a really good question. I think all of that is involved, but definitely I have thought about the business end. And I have preached that to others. I've heard, you know, I forget who it was, it was someone at Berklee it was like the music business person there, and they said if you want to make it in today's industry it's going to be ten percent your craft, which is like the practicing and the music, ninety percent business. And I'm like what? If I'm practicing like six hours a day that's only ten percent of making it? Like there's not enough time. And I wouldn't say I've devoted nine times as much to the business side but it is something that I just think today's musicians, you know, gone are the labels that are looking for young talent we're going to make you a star and you're going to make it rich when you go to New York City and you get discovered, and look at these huge jazz clubs with thousands of people in them. Heck no. If you want to make it you have to think of yourself as an entrepreneur, unless you maybe have these extremely serendipitous moments. And I think that still you have to be kind of lucky also. But yeah, it takes a lot of thinking. I mean we have these amazing, I often tell people this day and age in the music industry, not counting the pandemic that we're in, because we'll get beyond this, but today in the twenty-first century it's the best of times and it's the worst

technology, we can record albums in our bedrooms, as I did my first two albums, with a free program that was pre-installed on my computer. Garage Band. I made entire album from Garage Band, with two microphones that cost a hundred bucks each. You know that's unreal compared to thirty years ago. And I think it sounds good. To me it does. So that's amazing. And we have this technology where at the touch of a couple of buttons we can upload our music and videos for free, that's crazy. And it has the chance of being spread around the world. I mean that's crazy. However, the flip side of that is that well that technology is so easy to use, so inexpensive, everybody is using that technology, everybody knows how to use it, everybody is making an album. It's not a big deal anymore. Plus with stuff like the internet, YouTube, social media, everybody is posting videos all the time. And a lot of them are really, really good. And so that question, that million dollar question becomes like what makes me unique? What is it that I have to say? Why would anyone listen to me over the other ten thousand sax players that are probably better than me? There's always someone practicing more. There's always someone better. And so I've had a lot of these just kind of hard moments where I just have to like listen to myself really honestly and this is a thing a lot of us musicians are afraid of doing, just artists in general, it's like sitting back and do a hard listen. And saying like is this something that I would actually enjoy? Is this something I would seek out? Would I pay money to listen to this? Would I watch this whole video myself? And I think a lot of us are afraid of asking that. I find myself all the time still doing that and I have to force myself to ask that. And then also this idea of how do you get noticed? If you have a really good product, so many musicians, so many jazz musicians are famous, well not famous, but it's notorious for these amazing best players in the world and they're playing in some dark, tiny little closet practically in some tiny city or a big city and no one knows who they are. And for a lot of people that's fine. And that's great. And maybe they have a day job and that's great. Good for them, that's awesome. But like I said to you, for me music is a language, it's a communication. And I actually want to think about is this communicating. Is this getting to people? It doesn't mean I have to dumb it down but like just putting myself in the audience shoes, and like would I listen to this. Would this grab my attention?

MR: It must have grabbed your personal attention when you realized that you had the facility, you had like this super embouchure. Right?

DB: Well I didn't know it.

MR: Well okay. It probably didn't happen overnight. But you realized in the practice room somewhere, okay I can slap tongue and now what's the next step and you start adding these things on. And I'm trying to think of what my question is, but you're talking about

would I listen to that and so when was the first time you tried that by yourself in front of an audience?

DB: Oh yeah, yeah. Well a cool thing is that I was able to do it online first in the sense of posting a YouTube video. Yes I had experimented a little bit before. I was teaching down in Texas, Abeline Christian University, I was a full time instructor for six years. And that time was really good for me. So I did undergrad, Hope College; graduate school University of Cincinnati. And when you're a student you're learning so, so much. But there's also this kind of underwritten kind of competition. There's this intensity of kind of always comparing yourself. And I didn't do so well with that. Like I think it was good for my growth and getting me to practice, because wow, they practice a lot, that's what I'm going to do. But I almost kind of burnt out at that point. And that was when I didn't know what I had to say, I didn't know what kind of music I wanted to play. I was studying kind of more or less traditional jazz. But then it took me, moving down to Texas and being a professor. And I had income coming in, I had free time on my hands, and it was like oh yeah, I have this saxophone here. Am I going to practice? I should practice this. What do I want — and there was this freedom to like, if I'm going to play this thing I'm just going to play it exactly how I want to play. I'm not going to play it — I'm not going to do the things that other people want me to do, the things that a good jazz musician is supposed to do. Yeah sometimes I would do that stuff, because I wanted to be good at improvising. But it was like that slap tonguing thing that I remember hearing, I want to figure that out. That's really cool to me. And so I don't care if I take three hours just straight up working on slap tongue each day, I'm going to do it, because I can. And I know not everyone has that luxury. And I'm even grateful — I think if I had moved to like New York City right after grad school and into that scene, I don't think I ever would have kind of come across this solo type of playing. Because I would have just been hustling trying to get every gig, every group I could do, I'd be doing wedding bands, bar mitzvahs, all that. And that's good stuff. And some people, and I don't want to knock that stuff because some people do that stuff, they love it, they thrive with it and they still have time on their own to do that. But for me it was really good just kind of taking it a little bit slower after I had already worked on these skills of improvising and good tone in college. And now what do I want to do. If I'm really honest, what do I want to work on. Because I don't have to play this music. And that was kind of freeing for me. I don't have to play it. And so if I'm going to play it I'm going to play it how I want to. And just slowly I realized I like this percussive stuff. And some of the people I was listening to like the Eddie Harris's with the jumping around of the octaves, and then the big one for me, Bobby McFerrin, of course not a sax player, a vocalist. But hearing him perform and

amazing stuff you've ever heard, and the most creative stuff, and just being like I want to be able to do that but on the saxophone. And so then slowly over the years progressing and adding — oh wonder if I could get — I had this pop sound, I wonder if I could kind of get a hi-hat sound, and then thinking, also thinking of other instruments I've explored. I've played drumset a little bit and thinking okay so where's my bass drum sound? Where's my snare? Okay could I do like a roll sound? And then okay I have a bass could I do a mel — and all of it slowly came together soon enough, it was like oh I have a song here, I'll post this online, let's see what happens. And this video that I posted, I don't know if it was like seven years ago, I called it Catch'em Up is the name of this composition that I wrote. And yes by then I had kind of thought of a name, BEATBoxSAX, just thinking like it kind of sound like beatboxing I guess, even though I don't actually, I've never practiced vocally beatboxing. And that video did really well, surprisingly well. Like it got up to 100,000 views in a couple of weeks. And I was just like what? Oh my gosh. Wow. Okay. I was a little, once again kind of a little addicted to the applause so to speak. And then it's funny because then right from then it was like, oh I need to do more, and I'll do a cover song of a pop tune. And I remember even getting into the whole game here, and that is what you have to be careful with these days as a musician is thinking okay my first video got this number of views, this next video is going to be even better, it's going to be a cover song, how could I do the angle, what's going to be the best way to get more — okay "Every Breath You Take" by the Police, here we go. I put it out, it does like half as well. And I'm like depressed. It still got 50,000 views which, a month ago I would have been amazed but it doesn't matter. So much in life is comparative. You know? We're just comparing. And it's just like only 50,000, and I was depressed. And from that point on I learned it's not about the numbers. Yes I want my music to communicate. I want to reach people. But I'm not going to obsess over everything of like oh what's going to get the best look? What's going to get the most views? It's got to be fun for me first and foremost. And then it's icing on the cake if it connects — well more than icing on the cake but it's just like that's the sweet spot. If it's something I truly love and it's resonating with people, that is the sweet spot. That's what I want to be doing.

MR: All right. Well speaking of sweet spot, your description of developing your thing reminded me of a quote. I was able to interview Harry "Sweets" Edison, the trumpet player from the Basie era. And he was talking about when he was a young man, this would have been the late 1930s, he said this about the already-established musicians like Louis Armstrong and Coleman Hawkins. And what he said was, "Everybody had a sound of their own, a sound that could be recognized. That was our ambition in my day, to not

be an imitator, but an originator. We would rather be the world's worst originator than the world's greatest imitator.

DB: Yeah. I can resonate with that.

MR: Yeah. I was thinking about your sound and then the incredible breadth of saxophone sounds that have happened since the 20s. And so you're in the lineage, you're in the current lineage of what's going on now. Because sometimes I wonder does it get harder to come up with your own sound? I mean how do you go beyond John Coltrane's harmonic innovations and so if I can't do that what can I do?

DB: Yeah well I mean I had like a kind of musical mid-life crisis in grad school, that period where I was working really hard but kind of burning out at the same time. And it came from, I specifically remember the moment. I was second year grad school — I was a grad assistant so I was supposed to be one of the top people. I was getting paid to be in school. I was in charge of a quote unquote beginning jazz combo with some freshman in it. And in came this punk saxophone kid who played circles around me. He was twice as good as me. I was five years older. He was twice as good and it just drove me nuts. I'm sure other musicians can relate to this. It's impossible not to compare ourselves. But it drove me nuts and I remember thinking like I'm twice his age, surely I've practiced more than him, does he just have something in him? And it made me think if I'm not the best one in this room, I'm not the best one at all in Cincinnati. I'm definitely far from the best — how am I going to make a name for myself out there? How am I going to get noticed? And thinking about all the internet things and what is it, why would anyone listen to me when there are people twice as good as me. And I worked so hard for this. That is so hard. Now I wish I could say that then something switched and it was like oh I'll do BEATBoxSAX and I'll do solo concerts and I'll do all these extended — no of course it never works that cleanly and you go through some really dark, hard times. But that was right around the time that I got that teaching gig in Texas and so I had that time to just realize you know what? I'm going to stop just completely only trying to imitate people, because I wanted to be the next Sonny Rollins. He was my gut at that time. And I realized there's ten thousand other sax players that want to be exactly like Sonny Rollins. And then the crazy thing is none of us will ever be exactly Sonny Rollins because, you know, he had his way of playing and he had his own life, you know, influences. We'll never be that same way. And so it was just like once again, if I'm going to play this instrument it's going to be exactly how I want to play it. I wasn't even at that point thinking, dreaming so much about a performing career. I think I was probably thinking it wasn't going to happen when I got that teaching job. I'm not saying that I was like giving up or anything, because that was a great, great gig. But it did allow me to kind of relax, like I said, and just pursue

unique sound, it was just truly seeking what I like. And that's another thing with that whole honestly listening to yourself. I think more musicians, or a lot of musicians, need to be honest about what they truly like in music. It's kind of like when I was a teacher and I was teaching some of these saxophone majors, they were majors in music. They wanted to perform for a living. And like let's say it was a classical student. And I'd say, hey have you listened to this piece? What recordings do you like? And they were like, no. And then have you listened to any classical saxophone? And it's like they don't listen to classical saxophone at all. Like almost never. And it's like you're pursuing this full time. Like this is going to be your thing, and you don't even really like the music? You know that seems strange. Or, and that's an extreme example, there are other people I think, they're imitating someone because that's who they think they're supposed to like. Or in the typical jazz hierarchy, in the evolution of jazz, you're supposed to start, like if you just look at Coltrane. You start with "Blue Trane" but then you move on. That's too simple now, you move on to "Giant Steps," really fast harmonic language. You move on to "A Love Supreme" where he opens it all up. And then you move on and you kind of don't look back, and you kind of, you know it's like it's a lesser form of music. And for some people that's great. If avante garde jazz is your thing and that's what gets you up in the morning, go for it. That's awesome. We need people in this world that are excited about what they're doing. But if you're doing that just because that's what the other kids, the other sax players are doing, your heart's not going to be in it and I don't think you're going to have what it takes to push through the highs and a lot of lows of a music career. You have to absolutely love and be obsessed with the music you're pursuing. And that was kind of what I was getting closer to when I was coming across the music of Bobby McFerrin and Eddie Harris and that kind of idea.

MR: Well you just said, that was very informative and you said a word that I was going to get to. Do you think you're obsessed with your music career? Because I know how my mind thinks. If I'm working on an arrangement or something, and I take the dog for a walk, I'm like working on this thing in my head and I forget what I'm outside to do. Like I'm just standing in the sidewalk and the dog's looking at me like yeah? And I wonder if you are constantly trying to think what's next for me?

DB: I mean I definitely am, yeah. Because I have two little ones as we talked about, both under age two. And just the other day, walking him in his stroller and I was thinking what's another kind of song, a different approach I could do to a live gig. And oh wow, we're already at the park. So I know that happens. I think I have worked on the skill and I think you have to learn it, of also trying to be present in the rest of the world, like in my marriage and with my family. But I learned it the hard way in the sense of like having a

don't know what to do." And then my dad saying, "Hey, maybe you need a day off." I mean I had this conversation literally six months ago. This pandemic is bringing out a lot of issues I think, for us musicians. And it's a lot of good stuff we need to deal with if we deal with it. And it was, "Maybe you need a day off. Have you ever taken a complete day off from the saxophone?" And it's like, "No, that's the number one thing I preach is practice every day." And yes there's different types of people. Some people need to hear that, some people actually need to hear like too much. Like go see a movie you know. Some people need to hear different things. And I was that person. I needed to be told hey, you're only going to get this moment once when your kids are this little. This pandemic thing, there's a silver lining here. This could be a blessing. And don't over-do it. You know it's those cliché things we've heard, on your death bed you're not going to say I wish I had just practiced a little bit more you know. Or I wish I had worked a little har — you're not going to have that. It's I wish I was with my family more. And so that has been a hard thing but ultimately good that I've had to learn. Like a day off, it's important. Maybe it's not the best thing ever for my music, but I think it's the best thing for me as a person. And I hope that the best thing for me as a person also is maybe, in a way, the best thing for my music. I just finished a biography of Leonardo DaVinci. And it talked about how a lot of his biographers kind of lamented the fact that, you know he was notorious for putting things off, not finishing projects, working so much on theatrical stuff that we don't even have any records of what he did. He studied anatomy that didn't even have to do with his art, like into how the brain is shaped. And some biographers were like lamenting the fact like it's too bad that he didn't finish more, or that he didn't put that energy instead of opening up all these bodies why didn't he put that energy into doing more paintings? But then this biographer was really good at saying no that made him who he is, it satisfied his curiosity, if he wasn't doing those things he probably wouldn't have been so curious to do these amazing things, and who could fault Leonardo DaVinci for anything? For not doing enough. But yeah, it's one of these things where I hope that the better person that I become it translates itself some way into my music, similarly to, if we want to just look in the idea of music, when I practice like drumset, I think that's going to make me actually a better sax player. Or when I practice the guitar and think about that, it's going to make me a better sax player. And I can speak from experience, there are so many direct relations where wow that idea went completely from drumset to saxophone. I think like a drummer in that sense. Or the visualness of the keyboard. It definitely made me who I am and helped me kind of find my voice, just experiment with all these things.

MR: Did you ever have the experience playing in combos where you found it dissatisfying. Did that have anything to do with you choosing to be mostly a solo artist?

DB: Yeah. It's funny. I'm kind of coming around to the other side where my last two albums have now — the last one I just had was February 26 with Jeff Coffin, a duo, and it's just the two of us playing saxophone. And then the one before that I wrote a big band album and it's kind of my sound, it's called "All Figured Out." And it's with a complete big band. I wrote all the parts, and it's called "All Figured Out" as an ironic way of like I don't know what the heck I'm doing but this is fun for me. And now I'm realizing, it's kind of fun playing with other musicians, especially in this pandemic where like you literally can't. It's like man I miss that. But yeah, you know, when I was talking with Jeff Coffin, we've been talking a lot since the album. And we were both saying how frustrated we get sometimes with other people, and we always feel like we have to kind of take it all on our shoulders. I mentioned being kind of the goody two shoes of school, but also I was that like teacher's pet or the one who like, I hated group work. Group assignments in school, where it was okay you five you're going to do this play and you have to write some lines. And it always ended up just being me doing everything. Because I wasn't like satisfied with like, you guys aren't doing anything, I'll just do it myself. And then you know that could apply I think to some music things, or you have band rehearsals and like everybody in Chicago, everybody was late. It was just like normal to be 30 minutes to an hour late. And it was like come on, this is like wasting my time. It took me an hour to get here and also just not only the sense of wanting to play by myself but also like kind of organizing everything myself. You know we talked about the music business side, entrepreneurial thing, and you know there were times where I was hoping oh okay, because I have these videos, now I have a couple of endorsements with some saxophone products like Legere Reeds and people. Okay, things are going to start to come my way. They never, never come my way. And I remember one moment where I had just kind of gotten connected with this company and it was like they were saying some things they were going to do, some connections they had. None of that came through and so I remember just being like okay, screw it. I'm going to do this all myself. I'm going to find a list of every jazz festival, and I came across a really great email, website that had everyone in Europe listed, it was like 1,200 websites of different festivals. And I was like I'm going to send an email to every single one, and at the same time I'm listening to music business podcasts about like how to write an email, how to have your web page, how to do follow-ups. And so it's like oh I can't just to one email, I've got to send follow-ups. Okay every two weeks I'm going to send another email. I would send up to five emails to each of these places. And I'll tell people, like that first year I got like probably like six gigs in Europe. Six gigs, one way I could look at it is six gigs out of like 6,000 emails. That's pretty bad, pretty low return rate. But compared to

festivals, in Europe. That's amazing. And people don't have to know how many emails I sent, how I did it. But man I sure put it on my website, and hey, international musician. And then hopefully, yes, I can't send 6,000 emails every year, but hopefully it does get a little bit easier and it has, as your name gets out there. But you have to keep doing the work and this industry has a very short attention span. It seems even shorter now with social media where you've got to be putting stuff out all the time. But just, I mean just a month ago I did another email round, completely by myself. My dad helped a little bit. But I sent another thousand emails or two, and this is thinking I don't even know if festivals are planning stuff. I don't know if universities are opening, but I've got to get stuff out there. I was feeling the urge to make stuff happen.

MR: You know some things never change. I recall when we started this project, 25 years ago, that I would be interviewing people like Clark Terry, at that level, and I would be surprised afterwards that some of them would hit me up for a gig. And the reason it surprised me is I just thought, you know being a fan of these guys that by this point in their career they had it made.

DB: Not in this genre.

MR: I guess not. It never changes. I listened to the big band thing on your website, "A Simple Gesture." Beautiful. And there's a part in the middle, about three quarters of the way through, I think it's like a B flat sus vamp type thing. And you're blowing over it. And I'm wondering beyond the percussive effects and the melodic lines you're playing, what's going through your head? Do you have music theory in your head? Do you have modes and scales?

DB: Yeah. So I mean I definitely studied all that, and when I was teaching in Texas I was also, in addition to being the jazz and saxophone guy, I was also the second year music theory guy. So all that stuff is floating around there, the diminished chords, the augmented sixth chords. However, a lot of that doesn't necessarily find its way into my music. I do think I am pretty visual, as lame as that sounds, when it is an aural sound. I do think of kind of chord shapes, arpeggios, and I also think of the numbers a lot, which it sounds lame when I'm talking about it like this. But let's just say that's how I practice a lot of times. I practice a lot of patterns. I do a lot with modes. I'm definitely not the one to be pushing the harmonic boundary. You know definitely if I have something new to offer the saxophone world, if you want to call it new and of course everything's borrowed, it's of course, yeah the percussive, the rhythmic elements, the putting together of the bass lines and the melodies at the same time, and the percussion. But if you listen to my solo stuff or my big band stuff, you listen to the chords, it's pretty simple stuff. And that's the way I like it. I have tried to break out of that, and like, oh I'm going to

fellow faculty members would like. And it never, I can never finish it. It just doesn't feel like me. I can't — just like I gotta have that backbeat. It just feels so good. And so yeah, in my playing it's very tonal. I'll sometimes do a little inside-outside. I'm a huge fan of dissonance resolving to consonance. Yes I mostly do consonance, but I'm not against dissonance at all. Hey, I love movies, and what is a movie without dissonance. And sometimes the deeper the dissonance the better the resolution. I wish — I need to preach to myself right now because I could go further with that and like take the audience to more dark places to then resolve. But I do have to say I'm not a huge fan of music that just like never resolves. Sometimes it's okay, you know life doesn't always resolve and that's okay. But when I listen to music I want to hear that but then I need that release. And another thing in my music, I just need something to hold on to. Yes, I can get lost sometimes, but man if there's like some percussive element or some repetition, I eat that stuff up. And that's one thing I wish some more, not all, but I wish some more jazz musicians would embrace repetition, wouldn't be so afraid of repetition. You know I think of a jazz drummer who is always [frantic scat] the beat is always somewhere different, and it's like constantly changing. When man, sometimes [slow scat] that feels so good. And you can see it at like a jazz club where you've got the musician, and people might be into it but as soon as the drummer starts going [scats] even if it doesn't belong everybody starts bobbing their heads, and then they move on four seconds later. And yeah that's fine. But like I love repetition. I think there's probably something natural, naturally human, you know you could probably look at like — the words are escaping me, but in religions where there are like spiritual experiences — I'm blanking on the phrase but like the repetition.

MR: The longevity. Yeah. I'm so glad you said that because I've felt the same way. I felt so out of it, some of the current music I hear, it's not only the drummer who is playing everything but the time, but it's the bass player too.

DB: Or the comping.

MR: Or the comping. And I feel like I can't even tell what time signature this thing is. And, "I'm sure you guys are good but I'm not enjoying it."

DB: And like I said, sometimes that can be cool if you're thinking of like taking the audience on a journey. We're going to go to an unknown place. Mystery. But then oh, okay, here's a little bit of home, back on the trail. You know I think a lot of humans, we just need that. And another thing is I don't want to tell musicians how to change their music or say like, "You need to make it simpler for the audience." Like it all comes back to being honest with yourself and the music you listen to. If you only listen to music where it's like super-confusing, you can't tell where one is or the tonality, that's great, and it would

being real to ourselves and then I do have to say I feel grateful that the music that I like to make has reached somewhat of an audience. Of course we always wish it was more, we can always compare it to more. But I'm very grateful, because like we said there are some people that truly like to make this music that's so esoteric and more power to them if they have the energy to do that. But I am grateful and that's where a little bit of luck comes in that the music that I actually like to make actually has connected with some people and so I'm very grateful for that.

MR: Well I see a tenor behind you.

DB: There it is. It's always behind me everywhere I go.

MR: Did you have to fuss with your gear so that your gear helped you get where you wanted to go with the way you play?

DB: Yeah a little bit. I mean I love saying that like man, it's the player that makes the music, it's not getting the right gear that's going to make you sound better. That is so, so true. And I could do this BeatBox stuff on any horn. But there are certain things that maybe this Jody Jazz mouthpiece is a little easier, or I like the feeling of the New Mechanics. There are some small things like the fact that, this would get really technical, I won't go all the way there, but when you slap tongue on the sax, my tongue is making a suction on the reed and it's pulling down the reed and releasing, and you're hearing the sound of the reed slap against the tip of the mouth piece. You can also go [tongue slaps sax] and get that kind of snare sound, but that's the sound of the reed slapping against the mouthpiece. And most typical jazz mouthpieces are really, they have a big tip opening. And so when you do that it's just much more tiring to do that, plus to get that sound you have to bite down on the reed. It's kind of like a slingshot. You have to put pressure against it and so when you release it it slaps. If you do that with a really open mouthpiece the pitch is going to go way up, and so a lot of my earlier career I was fighting with out-of-tuneness where my slap tongue notes were really sharp and tiring. And so over the years I've been trying to find kind of the perfect mouthpiece where it's a smaller tip opening but still gives me that power I need. Actually Jody Espina of Jody Jazz made me a specific mouthpiece, they call it the DB Beatbox, even though it makes it sound like, "Ooh if I get this I'll be able to Beatbox on the saxophone like Derek." It's just a normal mouthpiece, it has a smaller tip opening but it works, it's just good for me.

MR: So if you had five minutes before going to babysit your kids and you'll —

DB: Which I'll be doing right after this interview.

MR: I assume so. I've been there. And by the way, they're going to be saying this particular sentence fairly soon, and that is, "Dad, do you have a gig tonight?"

DB: I can imagine. So I'm enjoying that they don't have to say that all the time, but yeah. And

MR: What would you choose to play if you had a few minutes. Would you think of a key and a tempo or a groove?

DB: Yeah well it depends on what you want. Do you want me to kind of explain the process of how I put this together? Do you want me to improvise? Do you want me to play a tune?

MR: Yeah, maybe just a little improvising and then afterwards you can talk about how come I did that?

DB: Yeah okay. I will play, because I've started doing this more and more just straight up just improv, solo saxophone. So yeah, like a lot of times I do think of a key. So I'll think kind of D minor here, and we'll see if it stays there. It's always weird playing sitting down but I'm going to give it my best shot.

[audio interlude]

I'm realizing I could just keep going and going, but thank you.

MR: I loved it. And I was thinking about the fact that you do sit at the drumset and play. You know cause I could hear the bass drum going.

DB: Yup, and I'm stomping, I don't know if it's coming through but I have a box here that I'm stomping, and that was, realizing drummers use all of their appendages why can't I use my feet? Guitarists sometimes hit their instruments in certain styles, why can't I put a ring on my thumb and hit my saxophone on the thumb hook there, it's the one finger, my right hand thumb, that's not playing a note. But yeah, and a lot of what you're hearing in there, the biggest realization for me was realizing that I could kind of, in a way, get both a melody or harmony and a bass line, at the same time adding this percussive stuff, sometimes with the mouth, sometimes with the hand. And that was a huge thing with Bobby McFerrin, where just I realized when he was doing his solo stuff he's often got this percussive thing going on his chest, but he'll alternate between this low deep voice and then this high falsetto voice, and you have to be really accurate and really confident. He's got this [scats] and it makes it sound like, when you step back, you know you could realize okay technically nothing is happening at the same time, but it's happening so quickly and so fluidly that it kind of sounds like there's two singers, you know there's a high soprano and a low bass. And so that just got me to practice, you know, kind of coming up with my own exercises, a way of almost of getting like independence between higher register and lower register, so like playing, like a repeated note in the bass and a scale up top.

[plays]

Or reversing it, a repeated note up on top, scale on the bottom.

[plays]

And then where it gets tricky is now, maybe I could do a two note ostinato in the bottom while doing a scale in the top.

[plays]

Or whatever, start to improvise, or do the reverse of that.

[plays]

And now I'm working on, because I want to be even better at improvising at this, and I'm even trying to do more like traditional like swing stuff. And so I'm trying to think, what would a bass player do, like a walking bass line. Maybe I'll separate it but can I do like a scale, like let's see

[plays]

So trying to do a little step-wise in the bass. But you could see, over here I have these exercises, you can't see it right here, and I just have them numbered. "Bass, down three up three. Number 2 bass up three. Number 3 bass four. One through ten of different bass lines, and then on the right A through H different melodic stuff that I can do. And now I'm just piece by piece going through each one, it's painfully slow, not fun to listen to day after day, but like I said I think I'm a slow learner but all that matters is I just do it. You just get to it.

MR: It helps I think that you seem to be rather an extrovert.

DB: Ah, I have fooled you. I am a performer for sure. Maybe more of an actor. Okay when I am one on one or with my family, yes you'd say Derek is definitely an extrovert. When I am in front of audiences, Derek, wow, you're so lively, so much energy. A lot of people say the word energy when I'm on stage. But that is a thought-out thing. That did not come natural to me. I think I'm definitely more of an introvert. I would prefer when the gig is done to just go to the hotel and read a book by myself, and I can just whoo — and you should see me backstage before a gig. Like I get nervous every single time I play. Every single time. And one of the ways I trick myself is I try to kind of like rephrase it. Instead of thinking nervousness I think excitement. Take those butterflies and instead of calling that nervousness call that excitement. And then when I go out on stage, when they introduce my name I almost always run out, and it's just my way of being like, from the beginning, oh Derek is excited to be here, and it's me tricking myself, I'm excited to be here, hey everybody, and that did not come natural. I had to, the first, when I would do concerts early on I would write everything down and memorize it. And just like anything else I had to learn it. And there's no shame in that of course. If it came naturally or you learned it, you still have it.

MR: Awesome.

DB: And so that's where I am.

MR: That's great. Well we've talked for almost an hour, and this has been really very informative.

DB: Thanks.

MR: I want to know if you've ever had this circumstance, you do a clinic at a school and you know you show them your thing and a week later you get an email from the band director saying something like, "Thanks Derek, all my saxophone players are slap tonguing to the Elgar Variations.

DB: Yes, I knew you were going there and I love that I have the most direct example of that. I should pull it up on my phone but I mean it was a couple of years ago. And it's happened a few times but it was at a, specifically at a middle school. And I worked with the saxophonists and I showed them all how to do a basic slap tongue. Some of this stuff is really hard to do and so you can't just learn how to double tongue easily. You can't even learn how to slap — it took me nine months to slap tongue. But I have some other percussive sounds I taught them. And I remember getting an email the next day, he enjoyed the clinic and I could tell people enjoyed it. The next day I got a text and it was a video of a student and he was just going [percussive scat] and it just said a word that said "thanks" period. But then the kicker, here's the best thing, but then a minute later he sent another text and it said, "But you know what? He actually took his horn home and worked on this." And then the next day he sent a video of a tune that the guy wrote using it where he was kind of doing a note and then he did a pop and then a different note. It was really basic, but he said, "He wrote a tune. He's never written anything." And I was like, yeah, that's what I like to see, yeah, just to excite people. I'm not expecting or wanting other people necessarily to copy me but if I can do something that inspires some young people in some way, I know it's going to annoy some people. I know there's going to be a time where I see on social media other people kind of doing way too much poppy stuff where it's just not quite there and it's just like oh boy, people are going to hate me for like encouraging this. But if it gets people to find new enjoyments out of their instruments, where maybe it wasn't, and like I said, not everyone has to do this. No one has to do it. But if it does, that makes it worth it for me, just to inspire people to think differently. You don't have to play a certain way, there are different things you can do.

MR: Well on that note, I really enjoyed talking to you.

DB: Likewise.

MR: And I'm going to let you get back to your everyday life.

DB: Yes, that needs to happen.

MR: Yes indeed. So thanks a lot, Derek.

DB: You're welcome. Thanks for having me, Monk, and thanks for doing what you're doing. This is awesome, all the interviews. I was able to check some out, inspiring stuff, and really important to hear from all these generations of musicians.

MR: As I've said it's been a dream gig for me.

DB: That's awesome.

MR: All right thanks a lot.

DB: You're welcome.